

MIDNIGHT  IN MEXICO

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FILMED IN:

EXT. DUSTY ROAD - DUSK

A lonely bus rumbles to a stop on a cracked highway. The sun sinks low, bleeding red and orange across the sky.

The bus to town only goes so far, leaving **ARMANDO** (Played by **GAEL GARCÍA BERNAL**) still miles away. From his business attire, the city-clean-cut with slick jet-black hair, a pair of shiny new shoes and carrying nothing but a leather suitcase, he doesn't belong here. His clothes hang loosely, and his tie is slightly slanted, exhausted. Telling another story, as if he's been worn down.

The doors wheeze shut behind him and the vehicle rolls away, leaving him in the middle of nowhere.

A sign ahead reads: **SANTA VERA - 5 MILES**

The taillights disappear.

A long, empty road stretches ahead. In the distance, a small village—weathered buildings, narrow faded streets, and dim lanterns rising in the dark.

EXT. VILLAGE STREETS - NIGHT

Armando trudges into Santa Vera, a quiet villa consisting of cobblestone streets, and too many shadows. The people he sees are mostly women and children. The few men around are either elderly or strangely off, with eyes, casting quick glances.

Armando pauses at the only lively building in sight—a bar. Warm light spills through the doorway. He exhales, steels himself, and steps inside.

A soft wind rustles the trees. Somewhere in the distance—

A **LOW, DISTANT HUM**.

Armando shivers, pulling his coat tighter.

INT. (EMPTY) BAR - NIGHT

A **LONE BARTENDER** (50s, wiry, wary eyes) polishes a glass behind the counter. He barely looks up as Armando approaches.

His aged hands trembling.

Armando approaches, setting down his suitcase. The bartender eyes him, noting his foreignness then silently pouring him a drink.

ARMANDO
Una cerveza.

The bartender pours the drink, studying Armando's suit, and shakes his head.

BARTENDER
You're not from here.

Armando gives a tired smirk.

ARMANDO
No kidding.

The bartender slides the drink over.

ARMANDO (CONT'D)
I need a place to stay.

Then, after a long pause:

BARTENDER
No such thing here... stay close to
the light tonight, amigo.

Armando frowns, but the bartender turns away, already done talking.

EXT. VILLAGE STREETS - LATER

Armando walks away, searching for lodging. The village is shutting down—doors bolted, windows boarded up. Some with deep claw marks etched into the wood. A rather creeping sense of unease settles in his chest. Even the animals around—dogs, chickens are nowhere to be seen.

A **CHURCH**  tolls in the distance.

EXT. CHURCH - NIGHT

With nowhere else to go, Armando heads for the **STONE CHURCH**, its old wooden doors slightly ajar.

Armando lingers in the doorway.

BISHOP TOMÁS (70s, frail but wise old man), opens hesitant.

ARMANDO
Father, I need somewhere to stay.
Just for the night.

The bishop turns slowly, his face unreadable. Behind him, a **YOUNG ACOLYTE** nails wooden planks across the windows.

BISHOP THOMAS
Come in...

Armando enters.

ARMANDO
What's going on with this town?

The bishop gestures to the wooden cross above them.

BISHOP THOMAS
What comes with the night...
is not of God

INT. CHURCH ROOM - LATER THAT NIGHT

The candle's light barely reaching the edges of the small, as if the room itself shudders. The scent of aged wood and melted wax lingers. ARMANDO sits on the edge of the bed, boots still on, staring at the floor. His hands rest on his knees, fingers tapping absently—restless.

A knock at the door. It creaks open, revealing BISHOP THOMAS, his long robe trailing slightly as he steps inside, holding a flask and a worn cloth.

BISHOP THOMAS
You're not sleeping.

Armando exhales sharply but doesn't look up.

BISHOP THOMAS (CONT'D)
A man with a quiet mind would be
but it seems rest is hard to come
by for men like us..

A silence lingers between them. Armando stares at the wooden cross above the door.

BISHOP THOMAS (SOFTLY) (CONT'D)
What brought you here, Armando?

ARMANDO
Didn't have a choice.

He exhales sharply, rubbing his face.

BISHOP THOMAS
There's always a choice.

Armando finally looks at him. His expression is worn, haunted.

ARMANDO
Not for men like me.

The bishop watches him closely, as if searching for the last piece of his soul. He leans forth, pouring a shot of whiskey and handing it to Armando.

BISHOP THOMAS
Then drink. If not to rest, at least to quiet the weight of our night.

Armando takes the flask, eyeing it before drinking. The whiskey burns, but he doesn't react.

ARMANDO (WINCES)
Didn't take you for a doctor, Padre.

BISHOP THOMAS
I'm not. Just an old man who's seen too many people suffer in silence.

He pulls up a chair and sits across from him.

BISHOP THOMAS (SOFTLY) (CONT'D)
I also recognize a man on the run when I see one

Armando smirks faintly but still avoids eye contact.

ARMANDO
You offering confession?

BISHOP THOMAS (SHAKING HIS HEAD)
No. I'm offering clarity.

The wind howls faintly outside, rustling the old church windows.

BISHOP THOMAS (CONT'D)
What is it you're running from?

Armando tightens his grip on the flask.

ARMANDO

A past.

BISHOP THOMAS

You say it like it's haunting you.

Armando finally looks up, his eyes dark and hollow.

ARMANDO

Because it is.

He leans back, contemplating.

ARMANDO (CONT'D)

My son was sick. I did everything I could to save him. I played cards, dice, bet on anything that moved—just to keep him breathing another week. Thought I could outplay the devil himself.

watching the turmoil play across his face.

BISHOP THOMAS (AFTER A BEAT)

I see... Then you didn't come here for sanctuary, but salvation.

ARMANDO

Doesn't matter. He still died.

A muscle in his jaw twitches.

BISHOP THAS

And the men you owed?

ARMANDO

Came for my wife.

The bishop sighs, rubbing his chin in thought.

BISHOP THOMAS

Nothing I say or you do, will bring back your loved ones from the dead Armando. Have faith you will die a good man. Only faith will move mountains, my son. But silver moves monsters.

He reaches into his robe and sets a small, silver cross on the nightstand. The candlelight glints off its surface.

BISHOP THOMAS (CONT'D)
You'll need both.

Armando studies the cross. His expression is unreadable. The wind outside grows stronger.

Then— **SCREECH**.

The sound is slow, deliberate. Claws raking against the wooden planks of the church's doors and windows.

The candle lights **QUIVER**.

Armando freezes. The bishop just closes his eyes... as the first scratches echo against the boarded windows.

A latent hostility in the room continues to grow delinquently, something lurking unseen. The candle flames tremble even harder, large shadows painting an animal-like creature stretches unnaturally across the stone walls.

Armando grips the pew, his knuckles whitening.

BISHOP THOMAS (CONT'D)
Do not move. Do not speak.

His breath is shallow, chest rising and falling quickly. Armando's gaze darts to the boarded windows—deep, long claw marks already etched into the wood.

Outside, the sound of shuffling footsteps—but uneven. A low, guttural growl snakes through the cracks.

Father Thomas remains still, eyes closed, as if in silent prayer.

A **LONE CANDLE** goes out.

Then another.

Father Thomas finally opens his eyes, staring at Armando.

BISHOP THOMAS (CONT'D)
You should have never come here.

BANG!

The church door slams violently, as if something—something powerful—just threw itself against it.

Armando flinches, his heart pounding. He looks back at the bishop, but the old man's eyes are elsewhere—locked on the door, his expression a mask of quiet resignation.

The scratching grows more frantic. Hoarse. Inhuman.

BANG! BANG!

The heavy wooden door shakes with each desperate pound. A **WOMAN'S (30s, delicate)** scream pierces through the rain outside.

WOMAN (O.S.)
Padre! Por favor! Let us in!

A **FATHER (30s)** cries of agony follow, weaker, desperate.

MAN (O.S.)
It's coming! Please!

Inside, the Bishop hesitates, fingers trembling over the iron lever that locks the door.

BISHOP THOMAS
We cannot.

Armando jumps up, anger fishing in his eyes.

ARMANDO
You can't just leave them out there!

The Bishop grabs his arm, pulling him back down.

PASTOR THOMAS
You don't understand you foolish child. We mustn't—

The woman's screams grow louder.

Armando snaps toward the entrance. The heavy door shudders, dust trickling from the frame. He rips free and yanks the lever. The hatch bursts open.

The door flies inward. The injured father stumbles in, blood gushing from a deep wound in his stomach. He clutches his wife with his last bit of strength.

A **CHILD**, frozen in terror, huddles in. Armando rushes to sit beside him, shielding him instinctively.

TWO SERVANTS of the priest hurry forward, lifting the father and carrying him to the back. The heavy door slams shut once more.

Outside, rain pounds the roof.

The mother sobs in silence.

INT. CHURCH - LATER

The Bishop kneels beside the woman, whispering words of comfort. Yet, unease lingers.

BISHOP THOMAS
We must remove the body. If we
don't, it may return.

Armando's eyes widen.

ARMANDO
What do you mean "return"?

The Bishop and his servants exchange grave looks.

EXT. CHURCH GROUNDS - NIGHT

A funeral pyre is prepared under the relentless downpour. The father's body, wrapped in cloth, is carried outside.

A spasm—his limbs twitch unnaturally. The body jerks. Before Armando can react, clawed hands lash out, slashing his arm. He cries out in pain. The Bishop thrusts a **DAGGER** into the beast's chest. A piercing, devilish screech. The Bishop twists the blade—The beast collapses, spasming before finally falling still.

They set fire to the corpse.

Breathless, Armando clutches his bleeding arm.

Then—

A growl behind them.

BISHOP THOMAS
Quickly! We must return inside and
protect the women and child at
all costs.

WHOOSH!

Lunging from the shadows, jaws snapping. Before the Bishop can react—

CRACK!

It clamps its massive jaws around the Bishop's head and tears it completely off. Armando and the acolyte sprint toward the church back entrance, barring the door behind them.

SLAM!

INT. CHURCH - Soon after

ARMANDO stands near the altar, tightening the straps of his satchel. THE WOMAN clutches her child, stirring in his mother's arms, restless. Her face streaked with silent tears as she glances toward the lifeless body of BISHOP THOMAS, draped over a shattered bench.

WOMAN (WHISPERS)

What now?

Armando doesn't answer right away.

His eyes scanning the church:

ARMANDO (LOW, FIRM)

We leave, before that fucking thing
out there it comes back.

He moves toward the door, cautiously peering outside. The streets are empty. He gestures for the woman to follow.

WOMAN (HESITANT)

Where?!

ARMANDO (SHAKING HIS HEAD)

Don't know. Just away from here.

She clutches her child tighter, nodding reluctantly. As they step out, Armando adjusts the weight of the suitcase in his hand—the stolen money hidden inside. He doesn't tell her what's in it.

ACOLYTE SAM

Wait before you go, take this.

Handing over Bishop Thomas's Silver dagger.

ARMANDO

You're not coming?!

ACOLYTE SAM

No we must continue our service
here and pray. That "thing" was a
monster long before, even as man...
This village was founded by Puritan
exiles who fled south as far as
they could away from the Salem
trials. Among them was Jonathan
Whitmore, a man accused and
crucified for eating children
during a harsh winter.

(MORE)

ACOLYTE SAM (CONT'D)
His wife, Margaret Whitmore, was
hanged as a witch, but before she
died, she cursed the town...
The town tried to burn Jonathan's
body, but the next full moon... he
rose from the ashes—a beast,
neither man nor animal.

With the town looming ahead, their only choice is to keep
moving.

FADE TO BLACK.

CUT TO:

EXT. TOWN - NIGHT

Sleeping under a moonlit sky, unaware of the nightmare that
approaches. The saloon stands at the heart of it, its doors
swaying in the breeze.

A **DRUNKEN WANDER** stumbles through the streets, pissing
against a wall, humming a slurred tune.

A **PROSTITUTE** giggles, guiding another man toward an alley.
She stops, her expression twisting in horror as—

SCREAM!

Tearing into the drunkard, sending a fountain of blood
spraying onto the cobblestone. Then into the shadows of man
and prostitute.

INT. VILLAGE BAR - NIGHT

The creature drags a body into the streets, feeding on the
bartender next.

The bartender barely has time to react before—

SNAP!

Teeth sink into his throat.

Suddenly, another **SCREAM** cuts through the night.

Windows light up as terrified faces peer outside. The town
erupts into chaos—shouts, doors slamming, weapons drawn.

Men rush to arm themselves, holsters unbuckled, rifles
loaded. Boots stomp against dirt, torches flare to life.

They gather outside the saloon, encircling it, their breaths heavy with fear and determination.

Silence.

The saloon's barn doors creak ominously. The tension from before, is now suffocating.

A man steps forward—his **REVOLVER** gleams in the firelight.

The **SHERIFF**. His badge catches the glow as he loads **SILVER BULLETS** into his gun, one by one. He mutters under his breath in Spanish:

SHERIFF
Te tengo pinche rata...

He lights a **CIGAR**, takes a drag, then flicks a torch through the doorway. Flames lick up the walls.

Suddenly—

The creature **CRASHES** through the window. A blur of claws and fangs. It **SLASHES** the Sheriff's leg clean off. His gun fires wildly into the air.

Gunfire erupts from the townsfolk. A storm of bullets misses, ricocheting into the night. The Sheriff collapses, his body riddled with stray shots. Just like his bullets, bodies fall—**ONE BY ONE**.

Then tears through the townhouses, crashing in through windows. Clearing out anything and everything in sight. Screams rise in waves as door after door is broken down. The church bells **TOLL** in warning, but salvation is far away.

EXT. BASEMENT - NIGHT

In a dark, **CRAMPED CELLAR**, Armando crouches among terrified townsfolk. The mother clutches her child, muffling their sobs. Above them, the floorboards creak. Drool seeps between the cracks. The creature **SNIFFS**, sensing the fear within their adrenaline glands. It lingers.

Then—

A distant **COMMOTION** draws it away.

Clutching the briefcase in his hand, Armando presses it against the women's chest.

ARMANDO

Take this. Look at me, what is your name?! Whatever happens... take your son by the hand as hardest you can, then run... Cover his eyes and don't look back.

EXT. TOWN CENTER - NIGHT

Armando runs to the street, drawing attention. He looks back—the beast pursues, leaping between buildings, crawling over rooftops, closing the distance.

He skids to a halt at the cliffside. No way forward.

The beast **POUNCES**, slamming into his back. They tumble down the rocky slope, locked in combat.

EXT. CLIFF BASE - NIGHT

They land hard. The beast **SLASHES** across Armando's face. Blood spatters. He pulls his pistol—**BANG! BANG! BANG!**—the bullets rip into its stomach. Empty.

The beast rises. Towering. It lets out a guttural growl.

Armando tosses the gun aside and draws the silver dagger. He **SCREAMS**, lunging forward. They clash in a brutal struggle, rolling, tearing, stabbing. But the beast is stronger.

It overpowers him.

Claws **RIP** into his stomach. Armando screams as his body begins to change. Bones **SNAP**. Skin stretches. Teeth and hair fall away. His eyes flood with tears.

Then—

His own claws **TEAR** through flesh. He grips the beast's throat, yanking out its tongue.

INT. CHURCH - NIGHT

Survivors hide in the church, clutching their weapons. Hushing their whispers, as their anxiety suspiciously grow.

Suddenly—

A **THUD** above.

The creature suddenly breaks in through the roof, ripping into them. Blood splatters. Bodies, limbs and heads in pieces and halves. Flashes of red. Arrows fly, bullets crack, but in the chaos, they strike the innocent as well. Women, men, children—caught in the crossfire, their screams aswallowed by the massacre.

Chains wrap around the beast. Spears pierce its hide. It lets out a final, echoing **HOWL**. The moon fades.

Then, it falls.

His pupils fade to human form. The rage of what appears to be Armando, drains into emptiness.

EXT. TOWN ROAD - DAWN

The dust settles over the carnage. The once-thriving town lies in ruins, bodies scattered among the wreckage. Smoke and the distant cries of survivors mourning the fallen.

A breeze pushes through the street, lifting the torn remnants of a wanted poster—its faded ink barely legible. Armando.

EXT. BUS STOP - OUTSKIRTS OF TOWN - DAWN

The woman clutches her son close as they sit inside the bus, her trembling hands pressing Armando's suitcase against her lap. Her gaze is lost in the passing landscape, her face streaked with dried tears.

She hesitates before opening the suitcase, her breath hitching. Inside, neat **STACKS OF CASH**. A means to escape. A future for her son. But at what cost?

She closes the suitcase and looks out the window as the sign for the town fades into the distance.

FADE TO BLACK.